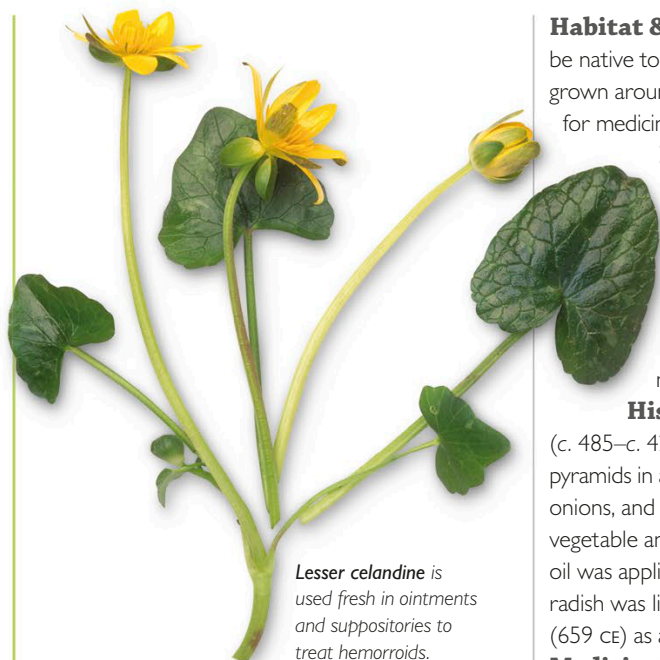




Lesser celandine is used fresh in ointments and suppositories to treat hemorrhoids.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Lesser celandine makes a useful ointment or suppository for treating hemorrhoids.

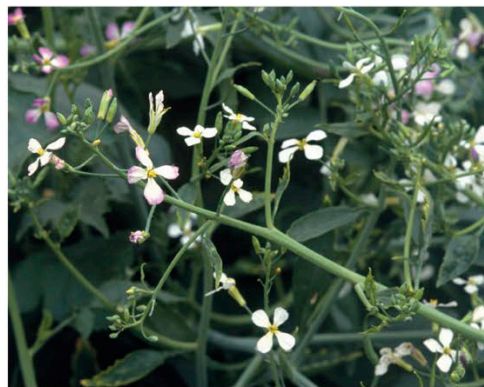
Related Species Various other *Ranunculus* species have been used in herbal medicine, even though all are toxic and irritant to a greater or lesser degree. In North America, the Meskawi people used the flowers and stigma of the yellow water crowfoot (*R. delphinifolius*) as a snuff to provoke sneezing, and mixed it with other herbs to treat respiratory conditions such as mucus and nasal congestion.

Caution Do not take lesser celandine orally.

Self-help Use Hemorrhoids, p. 302.

Raphanus sativus (Brassicaceae) Radish

Description Bristly annual growing to about 3 ft (1 m). Has a swollen taproot, deeply cut compound leaves, pale violet to lilac flowers, and cylindrical seed pods.



Radish has been used since the 7th century to aid digestion.

Habitat & Cultivation Radish is believed to be native to southern Asia. Cultivated varieties are grown around the world both as vegetables and for medicinal use. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Radish contains glucosinates, which yield a volatile oil, raphanin, phenolic compounds, and vitamin C. Raphanin is antibiotic; the phenolic compounds are antioxidant. The leaves are a highly nutritious and underused food.

History & Folklore Herodotus (c. 485–c. 425 BCE) wrote that the builders of the pyramids in ancient Egypt were paid in radishes, onions, and garlic. In Egypt, the plant was used as a vegetable and a medicine. In ancient Rome, radish oil was applied to treat skin diseases. In China, radish was listed in the *Tang Materia Medica* (659 CE) as a digestive stimulant.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Radish stimulates the appetite and digestion. The common red radish is eaten as a salad vegetable and an appetizer. The juice of the black radish is drunk to counter gassy indigestion and constipation. Black radish juice has a tonic and laxative action on the intestines, and indirectly stimulates the flow of bile. Consuming radish generally results in improved digestion, but some people are sensitive to its acidity and robust action. In China, radish is eaten to relieve abdominal distension. The root is also prepared “dry-fried” to treat chest problems.

Caution Avoid if gallstones are present.

Rauvolfia serpentina (Apocynaceae) Indian Snakeroot, Sarpagandha (Hindi)

Description Evergreen shrub growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has whorls of elliptical leaves, tiny pink and white tubular flowers, and glossy red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Indian snakeroot is native to much of southern and southeastern Asia, including India, Malaysia, and Indonesia. It is widely cultivated for medicinal use, notably in India and the Philippines. The root of plants at least 18 months old is unearthed in late winter.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Indian snakeroot contains a complex mixture of indole alkaloids, including reserpine, rescinnamine, ajmaline, and yohimbine. Ajmaline has been used to regulate heartbeat.

History & Folklore Indian snakeroot is listed in the *Charaka Samhita*, the earliest Ayurvedic medical text (c. 400 BCE). The plant has been used since at least that time to treat mental illness and insomnia. Indian snakeroot's status as a healing plant was first recorded in Europe in 1785, but it was not

until 1946 that conventional Western medicine recognized the herb's efficacy. After that date, the whole plant, and its reserpine extract in particular, were widely used in conventional medicine to lower high blood pressure and lessen the symptoms of mental illness.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Indian snakeroot is useful in the treatment of high blood pressure and anxiety. The root has a pronounced sedative and depressant effect on the sympathetic nervous system. By reducing the system's activity, the herb brings about the lowering of blood pressure. It may also be used to treat anxiety and insomnia, as well as more serious mental health problems such as psychosis. Indian snakeroot is a slow-acting remedy and it takes some time for its effect to become fully established.

Research As indicated above, Indian snakeroot and its alkaloids have been extensively researched since the 1930s. Despite concerns raised in the medical journal *The Lancet* in 1974, there is little evidence to show that the root has serious side-effects at normal dosage.

Related Species The West African species *R. vomitoria* is used as a sedative, aphrodisiac, and anticonvulsant in traditional African medicine.

Cautions Take only under professional supervision. Indian snakeroot is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Rhamnus frangula syn. *Frangula alnus* (Rhamnaceae) Alder Buckthorn

Description Deciduous shrub or small tree growing to 16 ft (5 m). Has smooth brown bark, oval to elliptical leaves, white flowers in late spring, and small round berries ripening from yellow to black.

Habitat & Cultivation Alder buckthorn grows in Europe (except for the Mediterranean region and the extreme north), and in northeastern parts of the U.S. It prefers marshy woodland. The bark of trees at least 3–4 years old is collected in late spring and early summer, and is dried and stored for at least 1 year before use.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Alder buckthorn contains 3–7% anthraquinones (including frangulin and emodin), anthrones, anthranols, an alkaloid (armepavine), tannins and flavonoids. The anthrones and anthranols induce vomiting, but the severity of their effect lessens after long-term storage. The anthraquinones found in alder buckthorn and closely related species act on the wall of the colon, stimulating a bowel movement approximately 8–12 hours after ingestion.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Alder buckthorn is a laxative and a cathartic, and is most commonly taken as a treatment for chronic constipation.